

The Maghrebi Desert: Imaginaries, Realities, and Lives



Why the Sahara matters in this class

- A geography of movement: trade across the Sahara, colonial borders, and today's smuggling, migration, and security routes.
- A site of extraction: phosphates, hydrocarbons, and water politics shape who controls land and who is imagined as “peripheral.”
- A laboratory: colonial mapping, military zones, and development projects treated the desert as a space to be tested on.
- A cultural world: oases, languages, and lifeways that refuse the cliché of emptiness.

“Deserts are not empty” (Henni, Chs. 1 and 2)

- The desert is not a blank. It is layered with histories, architectures, and claims, but maps and media often hide that.
- Power shapes what counts as “empty”: emptiness is a story people tell to justify extraction, control, or neglect.
- Reading the desert as inhabited resists both orientalist fantasy and the idea that only “modern” life counts as real.

Saharianism: imagination with consequences

(El-Guabli, Introduction)

- A bundle of images: timeless dunes, lawlessness, and mystique. None of that is neutral; it sells tourism, art, and state stories.
- When the Sahara is a backdrop, real politics (borders, minorities, repression) is easier to read wrong or to ignore.
- When those images meet violence, aid, and counterterrorism, the imaginaries are not innocent; they shape who gets hurt and who can push back.

143 Sahara Street (Ferhani, 2017): a different way of looking

- A fixed point at the edge: a small café and way station where travelers, workers, and chance meetings break the “empty” myth.
- The film slows time. Listening and daily routine matter as much as “events,” in contrast to action films or a narrow focus on jihad in the press.
- Cinema as a tool: the line between documentary and fiction works like the Sahara, both lived and staged in public view.

Reflection

- Southern Tunisia (from the steppe to the oases) sits on old caravan logic and new tourist circuits: the desert is both home and a marketed spectacle.
- Borders: proximity to Libya and Algeria means Tunisian deserts are crossed by the same securitization, trade, and migration logics the course names.
- Resources and periphery: phosphate basins, solar projects, and water use tie “empty” land to global economies and to local claims.
- Cultural life: oases, festivals (e.g. around Douz), and Amazigh heritage in the south complicate a single “Arab” or “Sahara” label.

Tensions to hold

- Transit vs. enclosure: who may move, and who is forced to wait or be blocked?
- Extraction vs. life: can a landscape be a “resource” and a home at the same time? If so, for whom?
- Experimentation vs. accountability: from colonial projects to “test bed” development today, who is left safe when the state or companies treat the edge of the map as a lab?

Conclusion: Maghrebi desert, many lenses

- The Sahara is a crossroads of trade, faith, and violence, not a void.
- Readings and film ask us to separate spectacle from context and to name the power behind stories of “emptiness.”
- The Tunisian angle means naming southern communities as actors, not as extras in someone else’s desert film.

For Discussion: Three Questions

- 1. “Empty” versus lived space: Whose story gets told when the desert is framed as void? What’s really erased, including histories, sovereignties, and ecologies, when we only see routes, resources, or threats?
- 2. Saharianism in practice: How do romantic images or images tied to security (El-Guabli) connect to real policies and everyday life in the Maghreb, including in border areas and the Tunisian south, and who benefits or pays the cost?
- 3. Grounded, patient work: What do ethnography, a film like 143 Sahara Street, and a refusal to pick one “desert” story add to public life in a region that is so often used to project fear and fantasy?